

the average has gone up from \$35 a pop to \$40 an application. The average high school senior will spend \$1,700 on application fees alone. You're spending a significant amount of money *just* to be evaluated and possibly rejected.

Speaking of which, I was dead-set on Northwestern University in Chicago because I'd heard great things about its journalism school and wanted to attend comedy classes at Second City, the former home of Tina Fey and Amy Poehler. I applied and waited eagerly for my letter. My second choice was Emerson College in Boston, which had a similar price tag to Northwestern of around \$40,000 a year (in 2006).

In April, I was accepted at the University of Florida. Florida has two long-standing programs that would have allowed me to go to UF essentially for free: Florida Prepaid, a prepaid, interest-accruing college fund that my parents had been paying into for me, and Bright Futures, a lottery-funded scholarship that allows a student resident who fulfills certain SAT score and community service hour requirements to attend an in-state Florida university for a huge discount. I qualified for Bright Futures. The other benefit was my dad had gone to UF, so I could also be considered for legacy scholarships.

I didn't care about—or fully understand—any of that.

As college acceptances neared, my high school did something I will neither forget nor forgive. The already competitive atmosphere skyrocketed with the placement of a bulletin board near the entrance to the school with every senior's name prominently displayed. Under our name, we were supposed to pin papers with our college acceptances and then a star or check beside the one we'd chosen to go to. Some of the honors kids were smart enough to get into Ivy League schools but took Bright Futures, used their prepaid, and accepted bids from local colleges like UF, Florida State University, or University of Central Florida (whose prestige was rising back then). The less wealthy kids who weren't going to community colleges were accepting spots at Florida International University or Florida Atlantic University, which I always thought of as proof they were driven or smart but just not wealthy enough. Most of those types (honors but not rich) accepted University of Florida's admission because even though it was in state, the school was starting to become "hard to get into."